

Session 4: A Mature Body

Key Takeaways

- The divisions among the Corinthian churches are evidence to Paul that the community is still immature and unwilling to embrace life in the Spirit.
- God is building his temple through the people of God; he causes the growth, but the community of Jesus' followers participates with God in that work.
- God calls us to be childlike in our acceptance of and need for him but mature in our emotions and relationships so that we mirror Christ to one another.
- Mature followers of Jesus are willing to answer God's call, surrender to his will, and exercise faith, believing and acting with trust that God will do what he said he would do.

1 Corinthians 3:1-4

How does Paul address their bad behavior?

Paul makes a reference to himself as one who gives “milk” and not solid food. This would have conjured up images for them of breastfeeding and mothers or wet nurses. There are other letters in which Paul refers to himself in female terms.

In Galatians 4:19, he says he is in the pain or pangs of childbirth (Greek: *odino*/ὠδίνω).

In 1 Thessalonians 2:6-7, he uses the word *θάλλω* (Greek: *thalpo*), which means to cherish, nurture, comfort, warm up. Paul says to the Thessalonians that he could have thrown around his weight as an apostle, but he was gentle among them as a nursing mother would cherish her own children.

In Ephesians 5:29, he uses this word with the word *ἐκτρέφω* (Greek: *ektrepho*—nourish, feed) with reference to how a husband should look after his wife and how Christ looks after the church.

In chapter 4, he talks about being a father to them which is also language he frequently uses. Paul casts himself as a parent of his churches.

The Servant of God

What does it mean to be a servant of God? To Paul, a *συνεργός* (Greek: *sunergos*), or co-worker, is one who works together with other workers and a co-worker with God. He and Apollos are friends who work together; they have a “common purpose” i.e., they are not divided, but of one mind.

Though it is God's own work, being co-workers means that we work! Paul and the other apostles plant and water, but it is God who gives growth.

The Temple of God

Note all the different metaphors Paul uses that all pile up on each other: parenting, weaning children, agriculture, temple pictures, and judgment.

God is building his temple through the people of God. This is God's work and he is building it, but what we contribute matters. Our contribution lies in the motives of our hearts. In 1 Corinthians 4:5, Paul talks about being judged on the motives of our hearts which will be brought into the light by God.

1 Corinthians 3:14-15 NRSV

¹⁴ If what has been built on the foundation survives, the builder will receive a reward. ¹⁵ If the work is burned, the builder will suffer loss; the builder will be saved, but only as through fire.

Paul addresses them as a group.

1 Corinthians 3:16-17 NRSV*

¹⁶ Do you not know that you [plural] are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you [plural]? ¹⁷ If anyone destroys God's temple [singular], God will destroy that person. For God's temple is holy, and you [plural] are that temple.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Then he switches to the first person in 1 Corinthians 3:18-23: "Let no one deceive himself/herself."

Here the verb is singular, and there is a reflexive element to this of allowing oneself to be deceived. It's not clear who he is addressing here, but he seems to be warning them to take responsibility for themselves.

1 Corinthians 3:21-23 NRSV

²¹ So let no one boast about human leaders. For all things are yours, ²² whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas or the world or life or death or the present or the future—all belong to you, ²³ and you belong to Christ, and Christ belongs to God.

What do you think he means by "all things are yours"?

1 Corinthians 4: Who's Judging Whom?

"Judgement and praise were significant issues in Roman culture. Certain innate attributes were generally considered honourable or praiseworthy—ancestry, gender, ethnicity; but these could be enhanced, destroyed, or bypassed by public actions that attracted praise or blame—such as benefaction or oratory. ... The wise person's disregard of human judgments is a theme of Stoicism. ... However, Paul will not allow his apparent indifference to be interpreted in a Stoic manner; his reasoning is explicitly theological and eschatological."

Malcolm, Matthew R. (2012). [*The World of 1 Corinthians: An Exegetical Source Book of Literary and Visual Backgrounds*](#). 1368.

1 Corinthians 5:12-13 NIV

¹² What business is it of mine to judge those outside the church? Are you not to judge those inside? ¹³ God will judge those outside. “Expel the wicked person from among you.”

1 Corinthians 4:6 NIV

Now, brothers and sisters, I have applied these things to myself and Apollos for your benefit, so that you may learn from us the meaning of the saying, “Do not go beyond what is written.” Then you will not be puffed up in being a follower of one of us over against the other.

“Do not go beyond what is written” in 4:6 is unclear. There is no real consensus on this.

Paul contrasts the Corinthians—rich, kings, wise, strong, and honored—with the apostles—last of all, sentenced to death, a spectacle to the world, fools, weak, held in disrepute, hungry, thirsty, poorly clothed, beaten, homeless, and weary from work.

1 Corinthians 4:12b-13 NRSV

¹² ... When reviled, we bless; when persecuted, we endure; ¹³ when slandered, we speak kindly. We have become like the rubbish of the world, the dregs of all things, to this very day.

Loving, Gentle, Fatherly Admonition

God calls us to be childlike in our acceptance of him and our need for him but mature in our emotions and our relationships so that we mirror Christ to one another.

1 Corinthians 4:12b-13 NRSV

¹⁴ I am not writing this to make you ashamed, but to admonish you as my beloved children. ¹⁵ For though you might have ten thousand guardians in Christ, you do not have many fathers. Indeed, in Christ Jesus I became your father through the gospel. ¹⁶ I appeal to you, then, be imitators of me. ¹⁷ For this reason I sent you Timothy, who is my beloved and faithful child in the Lord, to remind you of my ways in Christ Jesus, as I teach them everywhere in every church. ¹⁸ But some of you, thinking that I am not coming to you, have become arrogant. ¹⁹ But I will come to you soon, if the Lord wills, and I will find out not the talk of these arrogant people but their power. ²⁰ For the kingdom of God depends not on talk but on power. ²¹ What would you prefer? Am I to come to you with a stick, or with love in a spirit of gentleness?

Paul admonishes the Corinthians that they might become mature followers of Jesus who demonstrate a willingness to answer God’s call, who surrender to his will, and who have faith—believing that God is going to do what he said he would do and acting accordingly.

Reflection Question

What are a few of the key signs of Christlike maturity according to Paul?